运河人家

一条大河和一个家的四百年

The Canal Family

A great river and four hundred years of one family

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 有人说，运河[1]和别的河不一样。别的河是自然形成的，运河却是人一点一点挖出来的。别的河只往一个方向流，运河上的船却从南到北，又从北到南，来来去去走了一千多年。周舟[2]的家，就在这样一条河的边上。

石头上的名字

2 周舟今年二十六岁，是淮安[3]一条游船[4]上的导游。每天上午九点，船一开，她便站到船头，给游客讲河的故事："这条河就是京杭大运河[5]，北起北京，南到杭州[6]，全长[7]大约一千八百公里……"这些话她已经讲了四年，闭着眼睛都能说出来。游客们一边听，一边拍照，很少有人真的在听。说实话，她自己也不是每一句都在想。

1 运河 *yùnhé* canal
2 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
3 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
4 游船 *yóuchuán* tourist boat
5 京杭大运河 *Jīng-Háng Dà Yùnhé* Beijing–Hangzhou Grand Canal
6 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou
7 全长 *quáncháng* total length

Some say a canal is not like other rivers. Other rivers were formed by nature; 1
a canal is dug out by people, bit by bit. Other rivers flow in only one direction, but the boats on a canal have gone from south to north and from north to south, back and forth, for more than a thousand years. Zhou Zhou's family lives right on the bank of such a river.

The Name on the Stone

Zhou Zhou is twenty-six, and she works as a guide on a tourist boat in 2
Huai'an. Every morning at nine, as soon as the boat sets off, she goes and stands at the bow and tells the passengers the story of the river: "This river is the Beijing–Hangzhou Grand Canal. It starts at Beijing in the north and runs to Hangzhou in the south, about eighteen hundred kilometres in all..." She has been saying these words for four years; she could say them with her eyes shut. The passengers listen and take photos at the same time; hardly anyone is really listening. To be honest, she herself does not think about every sentence either.

那是2024年秋天的一个下午。游船[†]在一个老码头边停了下来。码头正在修，几个工人把一些旧石头从水边搬到了岸上。周舟[‡]本来只想下船透透气，不料在一块石头上看见了几行字。石头是灰色的，边上已经被水磨圆了，字也很模糊。她蹲下来，用手指摸着那些字，一个一个地读：“万历[§]十五年……修码头……船夫……周阿水[¶]……”

周阿水。她的心一下子跳得很快。小时候，爷爷常常跟她说：“我们周家的老祖宗，是一个撑船的，名字叫阿水[*]。”她一直以为，那只是老人讲给孩子听的故事罢了。她拿出手机，从不同的方向拍了十几张照片。那天晚上一回到家，她就把照片拿给爷爷看。

爷爷叫周长根[#]，今年八十六岁了，眼睛已经不太好。

† 游船 *yóuchuán* tourist boat
‡ 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
§ 万历 *Wànlì* Wanli reign (1573–1620)
¶ 周阿水 *Zhōu Āshuǐ* Zhou Ashui
* 阿水 *Āshuǐ* Ashui
\# 周长根 *Zhōu Chánggēn* Zhou Changgen

It was an afternoon in the autumn of 2024. The tourist boat stopped beside 3
an old wharf. The wharf was being repaired, and a few workers had moved some old stones from the water's edge up onto the bank. Zhou Zhou had only meant to step off the boat for a breath of air, but to her surprise she saw a few lines of writing on one of the stones. The stone was grey, its edges worn round by the water, and the characters were faint. She squatted down, felt the characters with her finger and read them one by one: "Fifteenth year of Wanli... repair of the wharf... boatmen... Zhou Ashui..."

Zhou Ashui. Her heart suddenly began to race. When she was little, 4
Grandpa often told her, "The first ancestor of our Zhou family was a man who poled boats. His name was Ashui." She had always thought it was just a story old people told children, nothing more. She took out her phone and took more than a dozen photos from different angles. That evening, as soon as she got home, she showed the photos to Grandpa.

Grandpa, whose name is Zhou Changgen, is eighty-six this year, and his 5
eyes are no longer very good.

他戴上眼镜，把手机拿得很近，看了很久。“是他，”爷爷轻轻地说，“就是他。”周舟[†]笑了：“爷爷，同名同姓[‡]的人那么多，您怎么知道就是他？”爷爷没有回答，只是看着窗外黑黑的河。过了一会儿，他说：“你每天给别人讲这条河的故事，可你知道我们家和这条河的故事吗？”

隋朝[§]的河

要讲周家的故事，先得讲这条河。中国的大河，像长江[¶]、黄河[*]、淮河[#]，差不多都是从西往东流的。可是古代的人想把南方的粮食送到北方，就需要一条南北方向的水路。走陆路运粮食，又慢又贵；走水路，一条船就能装下几十辆车的东西。

† 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
‡ 同名同姓 *tóngmíng tóngxìng* same name and surname
§ 隋朝 *Suícháo* Sui dynasty (581–618)
¶ 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River
* 黄河 *Huánghé* Yellow River
\# 淮河 *Huáihé* Huai River

He put on his glasses, held the phone close and looked for a long time. "It's him," Grandpa said softly. "That's him." Zhou Zhou laughed. "Grandpa, so many people share the same name. How do you know it's him?" Grandpa didn't answer; he just looked out of the window at the dark river. After a while he said, "Every day you tell other people the story of this river. But do you know the story of our family and this river?" 5

The River of the Sui

To tell the Zhou family's story, you first have to tell the story of this river. China's great rivers, such as the Yangtze, the Yellow River and the Huai, nearly all flow from west to east. But if people in ancient times wanted to send the grain of the south to the north, they needed a waterway running from south to north. Moving grain overland was slow and expensive; by water, a single boat could carry as much as dozens of carts. 6

7 大约两千五百年前，南方的吴国[1]为了往北作战，在今天的扬州[2]和淮安[3]之间挖了一条河，叫邗沟[4]。这段河并不长，却第一次把长江[5]和淮河[6]连在了一起。很多人认为，这是大运河[7]最早的一段。所以淮安人喜欢说，自己的城市是“运河之都[8]”。

8 又过了一千多年，到了隋朝[9]。隋炀帝[10]杨广[11]刚当上皇帝，便于公元 605 年命令人开河。据说光是其中一段，就用了一百多万人。这些河以洛阳[12][13]为中心，往北通到今天的北京一带，往南通到杭州[14]。前后大约只用了六年，一条长达两千多公里的水路就通了。

9 可是这条河，也是用人命换来的。挖河的人日夜泡在泥水里，很多人死在了河边。据说有的地方，连女人也被叫去挖河。

1 吴国 *Wúguó* the state of Wu
2 扬州 *Yángzhōu* Yangzhou
3 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
4 邗沟 *Hángōu* the Han Canal (486 BC)
5 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River
6 淮河 *Huáihé* Huai River
7 大运河 *Dà Yùnhé* the Grand Canal
8 运河之都 *Yùnhé zhī dū* capital of the canal
9 隋朝 *Suícháo* Sui dynasty (581–618)
10 隋炀帝 *Suí Yángdì* Emperor Yang of Sui
11 杨广 *Yáng Guǎng* Yang Guang
12 以 *yǐ* taking (as)
13 洛阳 *Luòyáng* Luoyang
14 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou

About two thousand five hundred years ago, the southern state of Wu, wanting to march north to war, dug a channel between present-day Yangzhou and Huai'an, called the Hangou. It was not long, but for the first time it joined the Yangtze to the Huai. Many people believe this was the earliest section of the Grand Canal. That is why the people of Huai'an like to call their city "the Capital of the Canal". 7

More than a thousand years later came the Sui dynasty. Yang Guang, Emperor Yang of Sui, had only just become emperor when, in 605 AD, he ordered people to dig canals. It is said that for just one of the stretches, more than a million people were put to work. These canals centred on Luoyang, reaching north to the area of present-day Beijing and south to Hangzhou. In only about six years in all, a waterway more than two thousand kilometres long was open. 8

But this river, too, was paid for with human lives. The diggers soaked in muddy water day and night, and many of them died on the banks. It is said that in some places even women were sent to dig. 9

9 河修好以后，皇帝坐着几层楼高的大船，带着几千条船，沿着河往南游玩。没过多少年，天下大乱，隋朝[†]就亡了。

10 后来很多人说，隋朝就是被这条河害死的。可是两百多年以后，唐朝[‡]诗人皮日休[§]在诗里写道：“尽道隋亡为此河[¶]，至今千里赖通波[*]。”意思是：人人都说隋朝亡于这条河，可直到今天，千里的土地还靠着它来往。周舟[#]每次讲到这里，都会停一下。一个皇帝的错，一条河的好处，哪个更重？她也说不清。

† 隋朝 *Suícháo* Sui dynasty (581–618)
‡ 唐朝 *Tángcháo* Tang dynasty
§ 皮日休 *Pí Rìxiū* Pi Rixiu, Tang poet
¶ 尽道隋亡为此河 *jìn dào Suí wáng wèi cǐ hé* all blame this river for Sui's fall
* 至今千里赖通波 *zhìjīn qiān lǐ lài tōng bō* yet still a thousand li rely on it
周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou

Once the canal was finished, the emperor sailed south along it for pleasure in a ship several storeys high, followed by thousands of boats. Not many years later the realm fell into chaos, and the Sui dynasty perished. 9

Later, many people said it was this river that killed the Sui. But more than two hundred years later, the Tang poet Pi Rixiu wrote in a poem: "All say the Sui fell because of this river, yet to this day a thousand li depend on its waters." What he meant was: everyone says the Sui perished because of this river, yet to this day a thousand li of land still rely on it to come and go. Whenever Zhou Zhou reaches this point, she pauses. One emperor's wrong, one river's good: which weighs more? She can't say for sure either. 10

明朝[1]的船夫

11 隋朝[2]以后，又过了六七百年。元朝[3]把首都定在大都，也就是今天的北京。为了让南方的船不用再绕到洛阳[4]，元朝在山东[5]一带挖了新的河道，把河“拉直”了。从此，船从杭州[6]出发，可以一直开到北京。后来人们说的“京杭大运河[7]”，就是这样来的。到了明朝，首都也搬到了北京。城里城外那么多人和军队要吃饭，粮食却大多长在南方。

12 周阿水[8]出生于哪一年，已经没有人知道了。我们只知道，大约在明朝万历[9]年间，他在淮安[10]的码头上当船夫，给运粮的大船撑船、拉纤[11]。每年春天，几千条粮船[12]从南方开过来，一条接一条，在淮安城外的河上排成长长的队，等着官府检查。

1 明朝 *Míngcháo* Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
2 隋朝 *Suícháo* Sui dynasty (581–618)
3 元朝 *Yuáncháo* Yuan dynasty (1271–1368)
4 洛阳 *Luòyáng* Luoyang
5 山东 *Shāndōng* Shandong province
6 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou
7 京杭大运河 *Jīng-Háng Dà Yùnhé* Beijing–Hangzhou Grand Canal
8 周阿水 *Zhōu Āshuǐ* Zhou Ashui
9 万历 *Wànlì* Wanli reign (1573–1620)
10 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
11 拉纤 *lāqiàn* to tow a boat by rope
12 粮船 *liángchuán* grain boat

The Ming Boatman

After the Sui, another six or seven hundred years went by. The Yuan dy- 11
nasty made its capital at Dadu, which is today's Beijing. So that boats from the south no longer had to go the long way round by Luoyang, the Yuan dug new channels in the Shandong area and "straightened" the canal. From then on, a boat could leave Hangzhou and sail all the way to Beijing. That is where the name "Beijing–Hangzhou Grand Canal" later came from. In the Ming dynasty the capital also moved to Beijing. All those people and soldiers in and around the city had to eat, but most of the grain grew in the south.

No one knows any more in what year Zhou Ashui was born. All we know 12
is that around the Wanli years of the Ming, he worked as a boatman on the wharves of Huai'an, poling and towing the big grain boats. Every spring thousands of grain boats came up from the south, one after another, forming a long line on the river outside Huai'an as they waited for the officials' inspection.

12 淮安[1]，是这条路上最重要的一关。

13 阿水[2]最怕的，是过黄河[3]。那时候的黄河跟今天不一样，它从淮安旁边流过，在这里和淮河[4]、运河[5]碰在一起。黄河的水又急又黄，河底的泥沙时时在变，一不小心，船便会翻。每次过河，十几个船夫光着背，把粗绳子[6]背在肩上，弯着腰，一步一步地在岸上拉。船上的人喊着号子[7]，岸上的人跟着喊，声音在河上传得很远。

14 万历[8]十四年的春天，河上刮起了大风。阿水他们本来以为等一夜就好了，不料风越刮越大，好几条船的绳子都断了。一条粮船[9]重重地撞在码头上，码头的石头掉下去一大块。有两个人掉进了河里。阿水想都没想，就跳了下去，把他们一个一个救了上来，自己却差点儿没能上岸。

1 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
2 阿水 *Āshuǐ* Ashui
3 黄河 *Huánghé* Yellow River
4 淮河 *Huáihé* Huai River
5 运河 *yùnhé* canal
6 绳子 *shéngzi* rope
7 号子 *hàozi* work chant
8 万历 *Wànlì* Wanli reign (1573–1620)
9 粮船 *liángchuán* grain boat

Huai'an was the most important checkpoint on the whole route. 12

What Ashui feared most was crossing the Yellow River. The Yellow River of 13
those days was not like today's: it flowed right past Huai'an, and here it met the Huai River and the canal. The Yellow River's water was fast and yellow, and the silt on its bed was always shifting; one careless moment and a boat would capsize. At every crossing a dozen or so boatmen, bare-backed, slung thick ropes over their shoulders and, bent double, hauled step by step along the bank. The men on the boat called out a work chant, the men on the bank chanted back, and the sound carried far across the river.

In the spring of the fourteenth year of Wanli, a gale blew up on the river. 14
Ashui and the others had thought it would be over after one night's wait, but the wind only blew harder and harder, and the ropes of several boats snapped. A grain boat slammed into the wharf, and a big piece of the wharf's stonework fell away. Two men fell into the river. Without a second thought, Ashui jumped in and pulled them out one after the other, though he himself very nearly failed to make it back to the bank.

15 第二年，码头边的船夫们你一点儿、我一点儿，捐钱把码头修好了。阿水[1]不识字，可是他也捐了。那几个钱，是他拉了几十天纤[2]才挣来的。修好以后，有人依照当地的老习惯，把捐钱的人的名字刻在一块石头上，放在码头最下面的一层。阿水站在旁边，看着那几个自己不认识的字，看了很久。“这是我？”他问。“这是你。”刻字的人说。他笑了，笑得像个孩子。

漕运[3]

16 把南方的粮食从水路运到首都，古代叫作“漕运”。明[4]清两代，每年运到北京的粮食，大约有几百万石[5]。管漕运的最高官，叫漕运总督[6]。从明朝[7]中期开始，他办公的地方就在淮安[8]。于是，这座不大的城，成了整条运河[9]的“心脏”。

1 阿水 *Āshuǐ* Ashui
2 纤 *qiàn* towrope
3 漕运 *cáoyùn* grain transport by water
4 明 *Míng* Ming dynasty
5 石 *dàn* dan, a grain measure
6 漕运总督 *cáoyùn zǒngdū* Director-General of Grain Transport
7 明朝 *Míngcháo* Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
8 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
9 运河 *yùnhé* canal

The next year the boatmen at the wharf each gave a little money, and together they had the wharf repaired. Ashui couldn't read, but he gave as well. Those few coins had taken him dozens of days of towing to earn. When the work was done, someone, following the old local custom, carved the names of those who had given money on a stone and set it in the lowest course of the wharf. Ashui stood to one side and gazed for a long time at those few characters he couldn't read. "That's me?" he asked. "That's you," said the carver. He laughed, laughed like a child. 15

Grain by Water

Shipping the grain of the south to the capital by water was known in ancient times as caoyun. Under the Ming and Qing, the grain shipped to Beijing each year came to roughly several million dan. The highest official in charge of grain transport was called the Director-General of Grain Transport. From the middle of the Ming onwards, his headquarters were in Huai'an. And so this modest city became the "heart" of the whole canal. 16

17 清朝[1]乾隆[2]年间，周家出了一个读书人，叫周文远[3]。他考了三次科举[4]，都没考上，只得到漕运总督[5]的衙门[6]里当了一个小小的书吏[7]，每天抄文件、记账。每条粮船[8]到了淮安[9]，都要依照规定接受检查：粮食够不够，湿不湿，有没有人往里面偷偷加沙子。周文远坐在码头边的小房子里，一条一条地记，一年要记几千条船。

18 那是淮安最热闹的时候。离城不远的清江浦[10]，南来北往[11]的人都要在这里换路：往北去的，下船骑马；往南去的，下马坐船。人们管这叫“南船北马[12]”。河边的街上，到处是饭馆、茶馆和仓库，盐商们的大房子一座比一座漂亮。据说，乾隆皇帝六次下江南[13]，每次都从这里经过。

1 清朝 *Qīngcháo* Qing dynasty (1644–1912)
2 乾隆 *Qiánlóng* Qianlong reign (1736–1795)
3 周文远 *Zhōu Wényuǎn* Zhou Wenyuan
4 科举 *kējǔ* imperial examinations
5 漕运总督 *cáoyùn zǒngdū* Director-General of Grain Transport
6 衙门 *yámen* government office
7 书吏 *shūlì* clerk
8 粮船 *liángchuán* grain boat
9 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
10 清江浦 *Qīngjiāngpǔ* Qingjiangpu, canal town in Huai'an
11 南来北往 *nánlái běiwǎng* coming and going north and south
12 南船北马 *nánchuán běimǎ* boats in the south, horses in the north
13 江南 *Jiāngnán* Jiangnan, south of the Lower Yangtze

In the Qianlong years of the Qing, the Zhou family produced a scholar named Zhou Wenyuan. He sat the imperial examinations three times and failed each time, so he had no choice but to become a lowly clerk in the Director-General's office, copying documents and keeping accounts every day. Every grain boat that reached Huai'an had to be inspected according to the rules: was the grain the full amount, was it damp, had anyone secretly mixed in sand? Zhou Wenyuan sat in a little hut beside the wharf, recording the boats one by one: several thousand of them a year. 17

That was Huai'an's liveliest time. At Qingjiangpu, not far from the city, travellers coming and going between north and south all had to change their way of travel here: those heading north left their boats and rode on by horse; those heading south left their horses and went on by boat. People called this "boats in the south, horses in the north." The streets along the river were full of restaurants, teahouses and warehouses, and the salt merchants' mansions each outdid the last. It is said that each of the Qianlong Emperor's six journeys to the south passed through here. 18

皇帝的船来的那天，周文远[1]跟着几千人跪在岸边，头都不敢抬，只看见了河水上一片金色的影子。

周文远一辈子没当上大官，也没赚到多少钱。可是他做了一件事：他把家里一代一代传下来的故事，写在了一个小本子上。本子的第一页写着："始祖[2]阿水[3]，明[4]万历[5]年间船夫，捐修码头，名刻于石。"后来，这个本子在战乱中丢了。可是那几句话，却被一代又一代的周家人背了下来。

火车来了

可是，再热闹的河，也有冷清的一天。1855年，黄河[6]在河南[7]冲破了河堤[8]，改道往北，从山东[9]流进了大海。山东的一段运河[10]被黄河冲断，河里的泥沙越来越多，大船慢慢地过不去了。

1 周文远 *Zhōu Wényuǎn* Zhou Wenyuan
2 始祖 *shǐzǔ* founding ancestor
3 阿水 *Āshuǐ* Ashui
4 明 *Míng* Ming dynasty
5 万历 *Wànlì* Wanli reign (1573–1620)
6 黄河 *Huánghé* Yellow River
7 河南 *Hénán* Henan province
8 堤 *dī* dike
9 山东 *Shāndōng* Shandong province
10 运河 *yùnhé* canal

On the day the emperor's boat came, Zhou Wenyuan knelt on the bank among thousands of people, not daring to raise his head, and saw only a golden shadow on the water. 18

Zhou Wenyuan never became a high official, nor did he ever earn much money. But he did one thing: he wrote down in a little notebook the stories that had been handed down in the family generation after generation. On the first page of the notebook was written: "First ancestor Ashui, boatman in the Wanli years of the Ming; gave money to repair the wharf; his name is carved in stone." Later, the notebook was lost in the turmoil of war. But those few lines were learned by heart by one generation of the Zhou family after another. 19

The Train Comes

But even the liveliest river has its quiet days. In 1855 the Yellow River burst its dikes in Henan, changed course to the north and flowed into the sea through Shandong. The Shandong stretch of the canal was cut by the Yellow River, the silt in the channel built up more and more, and gradually big boats could no longer get through. 20

20 与此同时[1]，官府越来越多地用海船把粮食从上海一带送到天津[2]。随着轮船的出现，走海路又快又便宜，运河[3]上的粮船[4]一年比一年少。1901年，清朝[5]正式停止了漕运[6]。几年以后，连漕运总督[7]这个官也没有了。

21 那年，周家的周德福[8]三十岁，在清江浦[9]的码头边开了一家小饭馆，专门做船夫的生意。以往，饭馆里天天坐满了人，南腔北调[10]，热闹得很。不料，船一年比一年少，客人也一年比一年少。有一天，一个老船夫吃完饭，叹了口气说："听说北边在修铁路，以后火车从天津一直开到长江[11]边，比船快多了。我们这些撑船的，以后吃什么？"

22 大约1912年，这条铁路全线通车了。

1 与此同时 *yǔcǐ tóngshí* at the same time
2 天津 *Tiānjīn* Tianjin
3 运河 *yùnhé* canal
4 粮船 *liángchuán* grain boat
5 清朝 *Qīngcháo* Qing dynasty (1644–1912)
6 漕运 *cáoyùn* grain transport by water
7 漕运总督 *cáoyùn zǒngdū* Director-General of Grain Transport
8 周德福 *Zhōu Défú* Zhou Defu
9 清江浦 *Qīngjiāngpǔ* Qingjiangpu, canal town in Huai'an
10 南腔北调 *nánqiāng běidiào* all sorts of accents
11 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River

At the same time, the authorities shipped more and more grain by sea, from the Shanghai area to Tianjin. With the arrival of steamships, the sea route became fast and cheap, and there were fewer grain boats on the canal every year. In 1901 the Qing formally ended grain transport by canal. A few years later, even the post of Director-General was gone. 20

That year Zhou Defu of the Zhou family was thirty. He ran a small eatery by the wharf at Qingjiangpu, catering to boatmen. In the past the eatery had been full every day, alive with accents from north and south. But to his dismay, the boats grew fewer every year, and the customers fewer with them. One day an old boatman finished his meal, sighed and said: "I hear they're building a railway up north. Soon trains will run from Tianjin all the way to the Yangtze, much faster than boats. What will people like us, who pole boats, live on then?" 21

Around 1912 the whole line of that railway opened. 22

22 周德福[†]特意走了好几天的路，到徐州[‡]去看火车。那是他第一次看见火车：一个黑色的大东西，冒着白烟，叫得比一百个号子[§]还响，一会儿便跑得看不见了。他在站台上站了很久，心里仿佛有什么东西也跟着开走了。回到淮安[¶]，他就把饭馆关了。这条铁路没有经过淮安。淮安人一直等到二十一世纪初，才有了自己的火车站。

一九五八年的渡口

23 1958年，周长根[*]二十岁。他只上过几年学，十五岁就跟着父亲在运河[#]边的一个渡口摆渡。渡口不大，只有一条木头船和一根长长的竹子。河这边是城，河那边是村子。卖菜的、上学的、看病的，每天都要坐他的船过河。依照父亲定下的规定，老人和孩子过河，一分钱也不收。

† 周德福 *Zhōu Défú* Zhou Defu
‡ 徐州 *Xúzhōu* Xuzhou
§ 号子 *hàozi* work chant
¶ 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
* 周长根 *Zhōu Chánggēn* Zhou Changgen
\# 运河 *yùnhé* canal

Zhou Defu made a special journey of several days to Xuzhou to see the train. It 22
was the first time he had seen a train: a great black thing puffing white smoke, its whistle louder than a hundred work chants, and in a moment it had run out of sight. He stood on the platform for a long time, as if something inside him had gone off with it. Back in Huai'an, he closed the eatery. The railway did not pass through Huai'an. The people of Huai'an had to wait until the beginning of the twenty-first century for a railway station of their own.

The Ferry Crossing, 1958

In 1958 Zhou Changgen was twenty. He had only had a few years of school, 23
and at fifteen he started working the ferry with his father at a crossing on the canal. The crossing was small: just one wooden boat and a long bamboo pole. On this side of the river was the town; on the other side, the villages. People selling vegetables, children going to school, people on their way to the doctor: every day they all had to cross in his boat. Following the rule his father had laid down, old people and children crossed without paying a single cent.

24 这一年，河上突然热闹了起来。大约从这一年开始，国家决定整治苏北[†]的运河[‡]：把河道挖深、加宽，让更大的船能通过。成千上万[§]的民工从附近的县里赶来，在河两边搭起简单的小房子，白天挖泥，晚上就睡在地上。渡口的船，从早到晚没有停过。

25 民工里有一个姑娘，叫李秀兰[¶]，每天早上坐他的船到对岸去挑土。她个子不高，力气也不大，挑起土来却从来不比男人慢。有一天傍晚，下起了暴雨，河水一下子涨了起来。周长根[*]本来想等雨小一点儿再开船，不料对岸还有十几个民工没有回来，李秀兰也在里面。他咬了咬牙，把竹子往水里一撑，船就冲进了雨里。他一共跑了三趟，一个人也没有少。

† 苏北 *Sūběi* northern Jiangsu
‡ 运河 *yùnhé* canal
§ 成千上万 *chéngqiān shàngwàn* thousands upon thousands
¶ 李秀兰 *Lǐ Xiùlán* Li Xiulan
* 周长根 *Zhōu Chánggēn* Zhou Changgen

That year the river suddenly came alive. Around that year the state set out to 24
overhaul the canal in northern Jiangsu, digging the channel deeper and wider so that bigger boats could pass. Thousands upon thousands of labourers came from the nearby counties, put up rough shelters along both banks, dug mud by day and slept on the ground at night. The ferry boat at the crossing never stopped from morning till night.

Among the labourers was a young woman called Li Xiulan, who took his 25
boat every morning to the opposite bank to carry earth. She was not tall or strong, yet when she carried earth she was never slower than the men. One evening at dusk a rainstorm broke and the river rose all at once. Zhou Changgen had meant to wait for the rain to ease before setting out, but it turned out that a dozen or so labourers had not yet come back from the other side, and Li Xiulan was among them. He gritted his teeth, drove the pole into the water, and the boat shot out into the rain. He made three trips in all, and not a single person was lost.

26 那天夜里，李秀兰[1]坐在渡口的小屋里等衣服干，问他：“你不怕吗？”周长根[2]想了想，说：“怕。可是我们家祖上是撑船的。听老人说，三百多年前，有个叫阿水[3]的，跳进黄河[4]里救过人。我总不能比他差吧。”李秀兰笑了：“你说得跟真的一样。”两年以后，他们结了婚。她就是周舟[5]的奶奶。又过了二十多年，河上修起了大桥，渡口便没有了。周长根又到船闸[6]上工作，看着一条条船从闸[7]里升上去、降下来，一直干到退休。

申遗[8]

27 2014年6月22日，周舟十六岁。那天晚上，爷爷一直坐在电视前面，连饭都没怎么吃。

1 李秀兰 *Lǐ Xiùlán* Li Xiulan
2 周长根 *Zhōu Chánggēn* Zhou Changgen
3 阿水 *Āshuǐ* Ashui
4 黄河 *Huánghé* Yellow River
5 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
6 船闸 *chuánzhá* ship lock
7 闸 *zhá* lock gate
8 申遗 *shēnyí* applying for World Heritage status

That night Li Xiulan sat in the little hut at the crossing, waiting for her clothes to dry, and asked him, "Weren't you afraid?" Zhou Changgen thought for a moment and said, "I was. But my family have always been boatmen. The old folks say that more than three hundred years ago a man called Ashui jumped into the Yellow River to save people. I can hardly do worse than him." Li Xiulan laughed. "You tell it as if it were true." Two years later they married. She was Zhou Zhou's grandmother. More than twenty years later a big bridge was built over the river, and the crossing was no more. Zhou Changgen went to work at a ship lock, watching boat after boat rise and fall in its chambers, until he retired. 26

The World Heritage Bid

On 22 June 2014, Zhou Zhou was sixteen. That evening Grandpa sat in front of the television the whole time and hardly touched his dinner. 27

27 远在卡塔尔[1]多哈[2]举行的世界遗产大会上，“中国大运河[3]”正式被列入了《世界遗产名录[4]》。新闻里说，为了这一天，沿河的几十个城市一起准备了大约八年。淮安[5]漕运总督[6]衙门[7]的旧址，还有清口[8]一带的古代水利工程，也在名单上。

28 宣布的那一刻，爷爷拍着桌子站了起来，又慢慢地坐下，半天没说话。周舟[9]那时不太明白：一条天天看得见的河，有什么好激动的？爷爷说：“以往，这条河是用来运东西的。以后，它还要用来让人记住一些东西。”“就是说，”周舟问，“它成了博物馆？”“不。”爷爷摇了摇头，“博物馆里的东西是不动的，这条河还活着。”

29 后来，周舟考上了大学，学的是旅游。

1 卡塔尔 *Kǎtǎ'ěr* Qatar
2 多哈 *Duōhā* Doha
3 大运河 *Dà Yùnhé* the Grand Canal
4 世界遗产名录 *Shìjiè Yíchǎn Mínglù* the World Heritage List
5 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
6 漕运总督 *cáoyùn zǒngdū* Director-General of Grain Transport
7 衙门 *yámen* government office
8 清口 *Qīngkǒu* Qingkou, old river junction at Huai'an
9 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou

At the World Heritage meeting far away in Doha, Qatar, "The Grand Canal" of China was officially inscribed on the World Heritage List. The news said that the dozens of cities along the canal had spent about eight years preparing together for this day. The former site of the Director-General's office in Huai'an and the ancient waterworks around Qingkou were on the list too. 27

At the moment of the announcement, Grandpa slapped the table and stood up, then slowly sat down again and said nothing for a long while. Zhou Zhou didn't really understand then: what was there to get so excited about in a river you saw every day? Grandpa said, "In the past this river was for carrying things. From now on it will also be for helping people remember things." "You mean," asked Zhou Zhou, "it's become a museum?" "No." Grandpa shook his head. "The things in a museum don't move. This river is still alive." 28

Later Zhou Zhou got into university, where she studied tourism. 29

29 毕业以后，很多同学去了上海、南京[†]，她却回到淮安[‡]，在游船[§]上当了导游。几年下来，她带过的游客，加起来已经有好几万人了。她以为自己已经很了解这条河了，每一个数字都记得清清楚楚。直到那块石头出现。

河还在流

30 那块石头被送到了当地的博物馆。几个星期以后，博物馆的一位专家给周舟[¶]打来了电话。

“从石头和字来看，它应该是明朝[*]后来的东西。上面一共刻了二十三个名字，大多是船夫。”专家停了停，又说：“不过，我们没有办法证明，这个周阿水[#]就是你们家的老祖宗。”“我明白。”周舟说，“就算不是，也没关系。”

† 南京 *Nánjīng* Nanjing
‡ 淮安 *Huái'ān* Huai'an, city in Jiangsu
§ 游船 *yóuchuán* tourist boat
¶ 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
* 明朝 *Míngcháo* Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
\# 周阿水 *Zhōu Āshuǐ* Zhou Ashui

After graduating, many of her classmates went to Shanghai or Nanjing, but she 29
came back to Huai'an and became a guide on the tourist boats. In a few years the visitors she had guided added up to tens of thousands. She thought she already knew this river well; she had every number clearly in her head. Until that stone turned up.

The River Still Flows

The stone was taken to the local museum. A few weeks later an expert from 30
the museum phoned Zhou Zhou. "Judging by the stone and the writing, it should date from the later part of the Ming. Twenty-three names are carved on it altogether, most of them boatmen." The expert paused, then added, "But we have no way of proving that this Zhou Ashui is your family's ancestor." "I understand," said Zhou Zhou. "Even if he isn't, it doesn't matter."

31 十月底的一个早上，周舟[†]扶着爷爷上了她的游船[‡]。船开了，她照样站到船头，可是这一次，她没有从“北起北京，南到杭州[§]”讲起。“诸位游客，今天我想给大家讲一个船夫的故事。他不识字，名字却在一块石头上留了四百多年……”游客们慢慢放下了手机。一个小男孩问：“后来呢？他的孩子呢？”周舟看了一眼坐在船后面的爷爷，笑着说：“他的孩子的孩子的孩子……现在就坐在这条船上。”大家都回过头去看爷爷。爷爷有点儿不好意思，摆了摆手。

32 船慢慢地往前走。一条长长的货船从旁边开过，船上装满了煤和沙子，推起一道一道波浪。很多人不知道，苏北[¶]的这一段运河[*]，今天照样是一条很忙的水路，每天都有大量的货船在上面来往。从2013年起，长江[#]的水还被一级一级地抽上来，沿着运河送往北方。

† 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
‡ 游船 *yóuchuán* tourist boat
§ 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou
¶ 苏北 *Sūběi* northern Jiangsu
* 运河 *yùnhé* canal
\# 长江 *Chángjiāng* Yangtze River

One morning at the end of October, Zhou Zhou helped Grandpa onto her tourist boat. The boat set off and, as usual, she went to stand at the bow; but this time she did not begin with "from Beijing in the north to Hangzhou in the south." "Ladies and gentlemen, today I'd like to tell you the story of a boatman. He couldn't read, yet his name stayed on a stone for more than four hundred years..." One by one the passengers put down their phones. A little boy asked, "And then? What about his children?" Zhou Zhou glanced at Grandpa, sitting at the back of the boat, and said with a smile, "His children's children's children... are sitting on this very boat." Everyone turned round to look at Grandpa. He was a little embarrassed and waved them away. 31

The boat moved slowly on. A long cargo boat went past, loaded with coal and sand, pushing up wave after wave. Many people don't know that this northern Jiangsu stretch of the canal is still a very busy waterway today, with large numbers of cargo boats travelling on it every day. And since 2013, water from the Yangtze has also been pumped up stage by stage and sent north along the canal. 32

32 有人开玩笑说：几百年前，这条河把南方的粮食送到北方；现在，它把南方的水送到北方。

33 船经过那个老码头的时候，周舟[†]停了下来，没有再说话。码头已经修好了。原来放那块石头的地方，放上了一块新石头，旁边立着一块小牌子：“明代[‡]船夫捐修码头刻名石（原石现藏于博物馆）”。爷爷看着那块牌子，自言自语地说：“人会走，字会模糊，石头也会被搬走。可这条河，还在流。”

34 周舟没有说话。她想起了那些她讲了四年、却从来没有认真想过的数字：一千八百公里，一千四百年，两千五百年……原来，这些数字里，也有一个不识字的船夫，一个考不上科举[§]的书吏[¶]，一家关了门的饭馆，和一条在暴雨里跑了三趟的渡船。河水从船边静静地流过，往北，也往南。

† 周舟 *Zhōu Zhōu* Zhou Zhou
‡ 明代 *Míngdài* Ming period
§ 科举 *kējǔ* imperial examinations
¶ 书吏 *shūlì* clerk

Some people joke that centuries ago this river carried the south's grain to the north, and now it carries the south's water there. 32

When the boat passed the old wharf, Zhou Zhou stopped and said nothing more. The wharf had been repaired. Where the stone used to be, a new stone had been set, and beside it stood a small sign: "Ming-dynasty stone naming the boatmen who paid to repair this wharf (the original is now kept in the museum)." Grandpa looked at the sign and murmured to himself: "People pass on, writing fades, even stones get carried away. But this river is still flowing." 33

Zhou Zhou said nothing. She thought of the numbers she had recited for four years without ever really thinking about them: eighteen hundred kilometres, fourteen hundred years, two thousand five hundred years... So inside those numbers there was also a boatman who couldn't read, a clerk who never passed the exams, an eatery that closed its doors, and a ferry that made three trips through a rainstorm. The water flowed quietly past the boat, northward, and southward too. 34